

would be closed to the world through late autumn, winter and spring. All that, however, changed last year with the completion of the Atal tunnel. As soon as I heard it was open, I knew I just had to head to Lahaul.

While getting to the Atal tunnel is usually easy, the road on the other side can sometimes be treacherous, especially for summer-tyred and 2WD vehicles. The black tarmac disappears and is replaced by a white track—there's some ice here and a liberal sprinkling of snow. While getting to the police check post at Sissu isn't too much of a problem, it is best to be cautious thereafter. If one loses momentum on a climb or if you stop to let another vehicle go by, you ought to be careful when restarting. It is, perhaps, ideal to deflate your tyres somewhat and to then forget using your first gear.

The Lahaul Valley in winter is like manna for the eyes, but the tranquility we found in its small towns was manna for the soul. One can go up all the way to Darcha, enjoying the many sightings of the Ibex and if lucky, of the black and brown bear, leopard, the Himalayan Thar, as well as some yak and deer.

We went in search of the Moravian mission in Keylong, only to hear that it was demolished many decades ago. If you are architecturally inclined, though, you can still find various influences of Moravian architecture on the houses in the village. The tower fort of Gondhla, for instance, a seven-storey structure built in the kath-kuni style of architecture, is a sight to behold. Its 18th century artefacts are a treat to explore. The pictures on these pages will, perhaps, better describe the beauty of the valley.



(Top) The tower fort of Gondhla, built in the kath-kuni style of architecture; the unparalleled joys of driving in Lahaul in the winter

Though this winter trip has only been made possible after much labour, time and capital, the joys of Lahaul in the winter are unparalleled. Sadly, though, we are seeing some worrying signs—construction along the roads continues unabated, and there are today more and more people venturing through the tunnel in order to get to the other side. The Lahaul paradise may not remain pristine for too long. ■